# FreeCEN Development Roadmap

*Last updated 30 September 2025*

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| This is a roadmap for the development of the FreeCEN2 software. Each Objective is specified to benefit a particular actor and outlines the high-level features or areas we expect to deliver or address for them.<br><br>Also noted are the data and documentation changes that need to be made in parallel with the software features being developed.<br><br>Software components: mongodb, Ruby on Rails, Refinery, GitHub Project Management. Agile software https://docs.google.com/document/d/1FNUijfW3586xE-m9W3U1gyxstSYwO7cD3jbqS9V33A8/editdevelopment process using scrum/sprint and GitHub.<br><br>Objective numbers refer to the steps of the FreeCEN2 (FC2) project.<br><br>Fortnightly software developments deployed during a version development. Note that while an Objective connotes the main emphasis of work, a version may include work from other Objectives if necessary and if deemed high priority.<br><br>Versions 1.0 to 1.3 are designed to get a system working so that FreeCEN1 can be frozen. At the completion of 1.3 all work in FreeCEN1 – including tasks in abeyance due to software issues for FreeCEN1 - can be done through FreeCEN2. Further versions are replacements for other FreeCEN processes which are not currently integrated, and enhancements for all actors. | FreeCEN1 has been frozen for several years and is available only for searching purposes. Some search functions are available in FreeCEN1 that are not yet available in FreeCEN2, FreeCEN1 has therefore not been closed despite the fact that the data set does not contain several million records that are only available in FreeCEN2.<br><br>The front end software used in FreeCEN1 was DOS based. As platforms and public software have been enhanced this software has gradually become unusable. With te advent of 64 bit Windows 11 none of this front end software now works satisfactorily.<br><br>As at July 2023 the front end of FreeCEN2 has been developed and is available to Transcribers, Proofreaders, Validators and Coordinators. It has been in use for almost 2 years and almost 5 million records have been successfully added.<br><br>The addition of vld files to FreeCEN2 have ceased and the vld data collection has been frozen.<br><br>All transcription and incorporation tasks are now done through FreeCEN2. |
| ## Objective 1 Set up basic website using FreeREG2 framework<br>## Targeted actors: Free UK Genealogy staff<br>*Features*<br>• MPN Master Placenames Collection, including Chapman Codes<br>• System Administrator Ability to manage collections<br>• All private functions behind security<br>• Tools to manage above collections<br>• Feedback collection<br>• Comments collection<br>• Documentation Repository<br>• Attic access | Completed |

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| • Basic usage statistics<br>• Server and Database monitoring tools<br>• Supercool's design implemented across the public facing pages<br>Tested on Cornwall and Durham data. | |
| Objective 2 Search of full database available on server cluster<br>Targeted actors; Researchers<br>*Features*<br>• All FC1 fields are presented in search results<br>• Coordinators list (Coordinators collection)<br>• UserID list (Users Collection)<br>• Direct access to search<br>• Search function stable under load with multiple servers<br>• Adverts are served and click-tracking works<br>• About page created, using existing FreeBMD content as a basis<br>• Access to donations page<br>• Help page created, using existing FreeBMD content as a basis<br>• Search paths and search features defined/developed through formative evaluation/feedback with users (all experience levels) iteration 1<br>• Nearby places search capability added<br>• Access to automated information on Database Contents<br>• Support to tablets<br>• Initial support for Smartphones<br>• About information<br>• Contact us capability<br>• Report data errors/problems<br>• Login in ability<br>• Simple navigation<br>• Information about the search<br>• Capability to revise search<br>• Multi-server deployment<br>• Daily update of database<br>• - Emailing of Coordinators, checkers and Transcribers.<br>• Mail-groups (replace rootsweb).<br>• Send out password reset request<br>• Transcriber registration/sign-up<br>• Transcriber Open Data agreement<br>• Application error reporting system | Completed |

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| *Researcher registration, and the extra features associated with being registered, is not part of this release.* | |
| Objective 3 Management Functions<br>Targeted actors; Coordinators and Proofreaders.<br>*Features*<br>• **Create new work pathways for use with existing spreadsheets #85, including**:<br>  ○ Transition from data being uploaded into FreeCEN1 and transferred to FreeCEN2 (current system)<br>  ○ Data is uploaded into FreeCEN2, and corrected there, and not FreeCEN1. #741<br>  ○ Manage their teams and control the metadata of the database as well as the quality of the data for their teams/counties. #742<br>• **New system - - CSV** (Priority - 23)<br>• **Quality Control (P19):**<br>  ○ Compare FreeREG2 Quality Control functions with FreeCEN2 needs and specify issues for this and subsequent milestones.<br>  ○ Quality control systems (e.g. CVS Check) include automated checking (e.g. of metadata) leading to rejection (nb need for transcriber-over-write of rejection for TWYS entries - 1.3 action) #116<br>  ○ Review work of their transcribers, errors and all vlds they have loaded. Quality Control takes place between Transcription and making transcription live. Multiple access means by errors/filename/date of load/userid/ #530<br>• Syndicate coordinator can review / add / delete / disable transcribers to their syndicate using variety of displays; lists by all/active/name/email address/userid P22#88<br>• Add information to profile of transcribers (P23) #1066<br>• send out password reset request<br>• **Coordinators features;**<br>  ○ can access all/active/specific places in their county. Add/Edit information about the Place. (P19) #529<br>  ○ upload new pieces/vlds (P16) #69 | Completed |

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| ○ Review and correct/edit errors and contents of pieces/vlds (P22) #530<br>▪ Correct errors in pieces/vlds online #361<br>○ Correct errors in pieces offline<br>○ Correct errors in vld offline #851<br>• Upload amended piece (P22) #528<br>• Download a piece (P18) #90<br>• Pieces/Vlds changed on-line will not be overwritten by a file reload (P25) #91<br>• Coordinators to have access to their own pieces/vlds and profiles (P21) #92<br>• Enhance CSVProc to accommodate Scotland #1060<br>• Report generator (P16) #93<br>○ recent additions URGENT #1076<br>○ Errors #1068<br>~~○~~ new stats page updated #749 | |
| **Objective 4 Transcriber access**<br>**Targeted actors; Transcribers**<br>***Features*** | |
| 4.1 Quality control systems include automated checking of some TWYS data (e.g. age of scholars), with over-write that prompts further checking | Definitions for all fields defined. England and Wales tested and implemented |
| 4.2 Spreadsheets for offline entry still needed for Scotland #927 | Fields defined for Scotland and Ireland. Spreadsheets designed but need testing.<br>2 years completed. |
| 4.2B Spreadsheets for offline entry for Ireland #1074 | Need to contact Ireland National Archives as a courtesy prior to commencing transcription from their public images. |
| 4.2C England and Wales 1921. | Spreadsheet structure developed. Waiting on creation of PARMS file for 1921 before 1921 spreadsheets can be tested. |
| 4.3 Tweak transcription rules to move to TWYS where now possible, and other changes to reflect new capabilities | Completed. All fields now TWYS |
| 4.4 Tweak spreadsheet so that contractions / concatinations don't happen and that EVERY field is recorded | Completed. New fields added to spreadsheets and guidelines defined. All TWYS. No size limitations. |

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| 4.5 Training module, possibly with video? #117 | Training videos are now available via links on FreeCEN2 pages. Training documentation is available via Handbook menu item. What else is envisaged here? |
| 4.6 Transcribers can log into the system | Completed |
| 4.7 Review and edit their profile. | Completed |
| 4.8 Able to use FreeUKGen methodology | KPIs needed to determine when this is achieved. Trustees have been asked to define FreeUKGen Methodology. |
| 4.9 Transcriber registration process #883 #542 | Completed |
| 4.10 Front end processor of transcriptions #127 | Part of FC2. Completed |
| 4.11 Close (freeze) FreeCEN1 | Completed FC1 Frozen |
| Objective 5 Search Engine Enhancements<br>Targeted actors; Researchers<br>*Features* | |
| 5.1 Common search platform be developed that will allow searching on either FreeBMD, FreeCEN or FreeREG and also able to provide one search on all three systems. | No story yet. Richard Light (FreeBMD) has lead on this project. We will need to develop the new search screens in conjunction with him. |
| 5.2 FC1 searches can be completed on FC2 #743<br>● Search by location/place (picking village name then auto picks country or option)<br>● Search by occupation<br>● Search by birth place<br>● Search by title (e.g. Rev. or Lord) #1064 | Cannot get down to village. Best we can do is civil parish. The search structure is that in the PARMS.<br>Search by occupation and Search by birth place cannot be achieved until the links between the FC1 data and the Gazetteer sorted out. Then all of these aims will be achievable to some extent. We will have problems with occupation because they are not standardised. However, we can limit searches by the use of sub-strings or using soundex.<br>FC1 now frozen. Civil Parishes have been reconciled with the PARMS.<br>Re-validation of FC1 POBs under way. |
| 5.3 Search returns ONLY Open Data records | I am not sure of the ramifications if we consider that all records are open data. I believe that in a |

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| | dispute we can claim that the work was donated for free public access. We will never be able to identify the contributors to FC1 so this aim, whilst it can be applauded, is impossible to achieve.<br><br>Recommend that this be removed from Roadmap |
| 5.4 Additional FC2 searches specified #1065 | Additional FC2 searches specified These cannot be achieved until FC1 is frozen and the links between the FC1 data and the Gazetteer sorted out. Then all of these aims will be achievable to some extent. We will have problems with occupation because they are not standardised. |
| 5.5 Daily update of database | Completed. We now have real time updating. |
| 5.6 Consider use of UCF for quality improvement #432 – originally in section 1.3.1<br><br>UCF Support in search engine #128 | This is a search issue. Moved to Search Engine Enhancements.<br><br>UCF-8 is being implemented on all broad text fields in FC2. These are the search fields most likely to be used as keys. Referred to Technical Committee for comment on impacts on other projects. Technical Committee approval received. |
| 5.6A Implement Gaelic Characters on search screen. | This is closely related to 5.6 UCF. Once we have UCF implemented Gaelic Characters will be possible. Referred to Technical Committee for comment. Technical Committee approval received. |
| 5.7 Consider a possible download in appropriate form of information contained in Records Information #1247 | Not sure what this is about. Can we add an explanation to the board please? |
| 5.8 Enhance use of Wildcard in searching#1071 Soundex can be applied to either first, ~~last~~, or both names #1071<br>5.9 Ability to search for (and using) double barrelled surnames #133<br>5.10 Enhance ability to search using titles i.e. Dr finds Doctor, Rev. finds Reverend etc.by using emendations (table showing what abbreviations | These are covered by a significant epic. FC2 is linked to the Gazetteer we should be able to include all these enhancements in one search update. Will be included in POB searching project. |

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| and alternatives of names and titles are to be used in searching #1088 | |
| 5.11 Allow researchers to enter Post Ems #1480 | This is already available in FreeBMD. It is a useful addition to FreeCEN. It should be done in conjunction with search coding.<br>There is a need for security checks here. Post ems will need checking prior to being made public. |
| Objective 6 End User Experience<br>Targeted actors; Researchers<br>6.1 Enhance information on updates to database #437 | Enhance information on updates to database #437 #437 is closed |
| 6.2 Review and enhance adverts - responsive units - and placement / pages with advertisements #1069 | Not within FreeCEN Committee's ambit or knowledge |
| 6.3 Improve experience for smart phone users. | Not within FreeCEN Committee's ambit or knowledge |
| 6.4 Researchers can register for free to get access to extra facilities. #130 | The story does not show what value we can add. If there is no value adding, then there is no point in this item. |
| 6.5 Saved Search features are accessible to registered users. | Why only registered users? Maybe we can make a csv download of search results available to everyone? It allows them to work through the results in their own time. We need to limit download size to stop plagiarism. |
| 6.6 Add processing indicator to inform user that search is proceeding | Completed |
| 6.7 Avoid gateway time-out | Recent enhancements have improved this. What is the benchmark we want to achieve? |
| 6.8 Enhanced tips and documentation | See #677 in 1.3 above. What is the definition of this being achieved? We need to know what the end target is. |
| 6.9 Features for FreeUKGen Integration Project Integrate searches with FreeREG and FreeBMD (including harmonising MPN) | Richard Light (FreeBMD) has the lead on this. |
| 6.10 Researchers can record where they have seen entries in the other projects. | This should be covered by Post Ems. |

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| Objective 7 Volunteer Enhancements<br>Targeted actors; Transcribers through to Coordinators<br>*Features.* | |
| 7.1 Error and usage reports | Needs more info please. Is there a story or epic that covers this? |
| 7.2 Enhanced and consistent validation | Completed |
| 7.3 Emailing of Coordinators, checkers and Transcribers. | I am not sure that email fits with our core business. Individual emails between Coordinators and transcribers work and there don't appear to be any issues. |
| 7.4 Mail-groups. | We have the message boards and they work but do depend on transcribers joining. Most choose to do so.<br><br>Our own mail system is clunky but can be used to cover all active volunteers, either across the board or within a County. It was successfully used on the FC1/FC2 cutover. I think this is very low priority. |
| Objective 8 Researcher Enhancements<br>Targeted actors; Researchers<br>*Features* | |
| 8.1A Enhance CSVProc to accommodate Ireland #1061 | On Ice |
| 8.1B Build Ireland PARMS | Preliminary feasibility spreadsheets containing this information have been built for one county (ANT) using data available from the Ireland census 1901 and 1911 indexes plus open data from Irish Townlands. |
| 8.2 Provide database statistics | Too vague. Exactly what statistics are required. We have done some recently and nobody has asked for more. What are the Trustees measuring success against? Statistics should reflect KPIs or they become meaningless. What are the KPIs we need to achieve? |

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| 8.3 Researchers can subscribe to receive emails when census returns change. | Have we identified the demand for this? Have our clients asked for this? If so, what have they asked for? |
| 8.4 Researchers can leave bouquets | Currently looking at directing Bouquets to Chris to include in the Newsletter. In Progress. |
| 8.5 Non-individual search pathways defined and implemented (e.g. search for all Boot-makers in Bradford in 1861, or all blind people in Bolton in 1891) | These would be special searches. It should be limited to specific researchers such as universities. They can then be given a data dictionary and permissions to search using sql, for instance. Need to be careful here as a poorly written query could slow us right down. So a data dump and let them use their own resources is far safer. |
| 8.6 Provide alternate text searching for non-individual pathways (e.g. 'labourer' finds 'ag lab') | Given that there are not standard abbreviations this is difficult. Spelling depends on the enumerator as we transcribe 'as is'. The best we can do is look for a substring with 'lab' for instance. But would it find every instance? |
| 8.7 Mouse-over alt text and/or hyperlinking of more obscure contractions (e.g. Chapman codes) | Chapman Codes are already displayed as the County in text form to the researcher. I am not sure which other fields are being looked at. Most are translated to text (e.g. Occupation employer, at home etc ). More information needed. |
| Objective 9 Image Management<br>Targeted actors All Volunteers and Researchers | |
| 9.1 Resolve Copyright issues around use of images | In progress |
| 9.2 Image management for work flow management | CAP implemented. Helen now populating data |
| 9.3 Obtain TNA approval to publish images and identify limits on use. | Referred to Brodies for advice. |
| 9.4 Integrate Image Server | Part of the Online transcription project |
| 9.5 Upload images into FC2 | Upload images into FC2. See my comments re indexing |

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| 9.6 All images to match Census records. | All images to match Census records. This will involve indexing of all completed transcriptions. It can be achieved via piece/folio/page indexing but will require significant work. It can be achieved piece by piece. On Ice. |
| Objective 10 Online Transcription<br>Targeted actors All Volunteers | |
| 10.1 CAP (a system to manage work in progress and available for transcription) – if not at online transcription at this point | Pilot system developed. See 9.2<br>This is a necessary part of online transcription and cannot be designed until the requirements of the online system are known. If the online system is not going to happen then we can design a system that will cover current needs, but we don't want to do it twice. |
| 10.2 CAP a system to indicate Gaps in Census information | Completed. Being populated. |
| 10.3 Coordinators can customise the CAP and RAP. | Our system is currently a catalogue of what is available. It is intended for the use of the Image Manager and should not be able to be amended o=by anybody else. |
| 10.4 Transcribers to select from CAP and get permission from Coordinators | This can be achieved once the CAP data is populated. |
| 10.5 Volunteers can review files their co-ordinator has uploaded | More information needed. What is hoped to be achieved? |
| ~~10.6 CAP integrated with DAP and GAP~~ | Completed as part of 10.2 |
| 10.7 Online transcription tool for users (P14): trial to determine if third-party software is sufficient for this #502 | Paul Tollemache completed a whole Somerset piece using the tool several years ago. This appears to have gone onto the back burner since then. If the results were acceptable, then this trial is complete. |
| 10.8 Online transcription (if FreeCEN2 is lead project) | Online transcription (if FreeCEN2 is lead project) – this flows on from #502. FreeCEN is not currently the lead project. |
| 10.9 Online help and documentation #677 | We now have comprehensive supporting documentation for the FC2 spreadsheet system. Again, I |

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| | believe that this is an online transcription issue. |
| 10.10 Front end processor of transcriptions. | This is either covered by the FC2 testing or it is purely an online transcription issue. |
| 10.11 Review and correct errors on-line. This will not be an online transcription tool; enables a missed entry to be added or one changed if better understanding of the content has occurred | There is capability to do this in FC2 from the personal details onwards. It cannot be done for items to the left to the name because these fields are carried down on Incorporation. The ability exists but is not encouraged for transcribers and proofreaders because it affects version control. This is now really an online transcription issue. |
| 10.12 Review and add/change records online (This will not be an online transcription tool); enables a missed entry to be added or one changed if better understanding of the content has occurred | This is now done via the spreadsheet. It cannot be done online as the header fields need to be carried down. I am not sure that the coding effort is worth the return as this is rarely necessary. It will be needed in the development of the online tool. |